

VEER

The No-Jargon Claude Glossary

Fifteen words, in plain English. Everything else you can ignore.

How to use this

Every field invents words. Most of them exist so people inside the field can talk quickly to each other, not to keep you out — but the effect on someone new is the same.

This book covers fifteen words. They're the ones you'll genuinely meet in your first month. Each gets a plain-English definition and, where it helps, what it means for you in practice.

It leaves out far more than it includes. That's deliberate. The last page lists the words you'll hear and can safely ignore, and why. That page may be more useful than the definitions.

Nothing here is technical. If a definition sends you looking up another word, that's a failure of this book, not of you.

01

The words for the thing itself

AI — A broad label for software that produces answers rather than looking them up. In this series it means one specific thing: an assistant you type to in ordinary English. The word covers an enormous range elsewhere, which is why it causes so much confusion.

Claude — The assistant this series is about. You reach it at claude.ai or through its app.

Anthropic — The company that makes Claude. You'll see the name in every legal notice, including the one at the back of this book.

02

The words for what you do

Prompt — The message you send. That's all it means. Not a magic phrase, not a special format — the thing you type. If someone says "write a better prompt," they mean "explain yourself more clearly."

Chat, or conversation — One session, from your first message to your last. Everything you say in it stays available to the assistant for that session, which is why a back-and-forth works better than one long request.

Upload, or attach — Showing it a file or a photo rather than describing one. A letter, a bill, a screenshot, a document. It can only see what you deliberately hand over.

Model — The particular engine answering you. There are several, at different speeds and levels of capability. In everyday use you don't need to choose: the app picks a sensible one. The names change often, which is why they live on the current-versions page at the back rather than here.

03

The words for how it behaves

Context — Everything the assistant is holding in mind for this conversation: your messages, anything you've attached, and its own replies. There's a limit to how much fits. In a short exchange you'll never come near it; in a very long one, the earliest parts start dropping out of view.

Memory — Whether it remembers you between separate conversations. By default a new conversation starts fresh and knows nothing about the last one. That's not a fault — it's the reason you sometimes need to re-explain yourself.

Hallucination — The word for when it makes something up while sounding completely certain. An invented statistic, a book that doesn't exist, a rule it has confidently misremembered.

This is the most important word in the book, and the ugliest. It sounds like a rare malfunction. It isn't — it's a normal, expected behaviour of this kind of software, and there's no tone of voice that gives it away.

WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT

Check anything you could verify in one search, and anything that matters. For money, legal matters, health, or anything you can't undo, confirm with a person. That single habit covers almost all of the risk.

04

The words you'll see in the app

Project — A workspace you set up once for a recurring situation, so you stop re-explaining your circumstances every time. Optional, and not something you need on day one.

Custom instructions — Standing rules you set once: how you want it to write, what to always do, what never to do. It follows them without being reminded.

Artifact — A document, table, or other finished piece it produces alongside the conversation, in its own panel, so you can read and reuse it separately from the chat.

Connector — A deliberate link between the assistant and another app you already use — your email, calendar, or files — so it can work with real information instead of you copying it across. It only ever exists if you set it up and approve it, and you can remove it.

Plan tiers — There's a free version and one or more paid versions above it. What the money buys is more usage and access to the more capable models. The names of the tiers, and what each currently includes, are on the next page — that's the part that changes.

THE ONLY ADVICE YOU NEED ABOUT PLANS

Start on the free one. Upgrade when, and only when, you notice yourself running into limits during work you actually care about. Nobody can tell you in advance whether you'll need to.

Words you can safely ignore

You will hear all of these. None of them are things you need.

LLM, large language model — The technical category Claude belongs to. Useful if you're building software. Otherwise it's the engine specification on a car you're driving perfectly well.

Token — The unit the system counts text in, roughly three-quarters of a word. It shows up in technical pricing. You will never need to count one.

API — The way programmers connect their own software to it. Not part of using the app.

MCP — A standard that connectors are built on. Plumbing, not the tap.

Claude Code — A separate product for software developers working in code. Different tool, different audience. If a word only ever comes up in a developer conversation, this is usually why.

Skill — A packaged piece of specialist know-how the assistant loads by itself when a task needs it. You don't install them or manage them.

Prompt engineering — An impressive-sounding name for explaining yourself clearly. The skill is real; the job title makes it sound like more than it is.

Fine-tuning, training, parameters, weights — All about how the software is built, none about how it's used.

WHY THIS PAGE EXISTS

Hearing a word you don't know is not evidence that you're behind. Most of these exist for people building this software, not for people using it. You can nod, move on, and lose nothing.

Current as of Q3 2026

The only page tied to things that change. Check you have the current edition.

The plans. A free tier that's genuinely usable, and paid tiers above it — currently a standard **Pro** tier and a higher-usage **Max** tier.

The models. You'll see the names **Opus**, **Sonnet** and **Haiku**. Same assistant at different sizes: Haiku fastest, Opus most capable, Sonnet between them. The current generation is the **Claude 5** family, alongside Haiku 4.5. In everyday use the app chooses for you.

VERIFY BEFORE YOU RELY ON IT

Plan names, prices and model names change regularly. Check the official source rather than a printed page — including this one.

Where to go next

Never used it at all? → Your First Ten Minutes With Claude — six pages, free, and you finish with one real thing you'd show someone.

Ready to set it up properly? → Claude for Absolute Beginners — the account, the screen, and the ten habits that make it work.

Cautious about privacy or accuracy? → Is This Safe? — what it can and can't see, why it's sometimes wrong, and the short list of things never to type in.

Want ideas to try? → 101 Everyday Things to Ask Claude — open at any page, find something for today.

The Everyday Claude Guides — start where you are.

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